

Comparative Political Institutions (Summer 2026)

Course Syllabus

Translated, Originally in Chinese

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College of Public Administration, Room 634

Office hours: Thursday, 10:00–11:30 a.m., or by email appointment

1 Course Time, Location, and Contact Information

- Time: Wednesday 16:15–17:50 and Thursday 16:15–17:50 each week.
- Location: Zijingang Campus, North Building 3, Room 115.
- Instructor contact: email (shaoli@zju.edu.cn); DingTalk ID: 14_2psuasvko3. I do not add students as WeChat contacts. Please check the course DingTalk group regularly for announcements, and feel free to ask questions there.
- Unless otherwise specified, Learning at ZJU (TronClass) will be used for attendance, assigned readings, assignment submission, and peer evaluation.

2 Course Objectives

1. Understand major theories and research areas in the study of comparative political institutions. Compared with *Introduction to Comparative Politics*, this course examines theories of political institutions and comparative politics in greater depth. Some course activities require students to investigate and reason through problems independently.
2. Develop the ability to read political science research, write a literature review, and formulate research questions. The course places particular emphasis on explaining the logic of selected studies.
3. Build on the knowledge introduced in *Introduction to Comparative Politics*. Students without that background may still take the course, although they may need additional time to become familiar with the topics and research conventions of political science. Basic concepts covered in the introductory course will not be reviewed in detail. Please raise questions whenever clarification is needed.

3 Assignments and Assessment

3.1 Assessment

The final grade consists of class participation, team projects, and a final paper.

- Class participation: 20%.
 1. Attendance (10%): Attendance is required, but one unexcused absence is permitted without penalty.
 2. Class engagement (10%): Each week, students who are not presenting must post at least one question based on the readings and course topic in Learning at ZJU. They must also answer at least one classmate's question, use an AI tool to answer it, or comment on an AI-generated answer by stating whether

they agree or disagree and explaining why. Students may answer their own questions. **Both tasks must be completed before that class session to receive credit.** Identify the AI tool used; if the tool cannot answer the question, report that result. **To facilitate discussion, I will ask students in Groups A and B to respond to questions raised by the instructor and their classmates during class.**

- Team projects: 40% (20% each).
- Final paper: 40%.

In addition to the rules above, I reserve the right to award bonus credit to students who perform exceptionally well or make substantial progress, and to penalize students who do not engage seriously with the course.

I may use AI software to simulate student writing submissions. **A passing writing assignment must be better than what AI software can produce.**

3.2 Team Projects

Each team will consist of three or four students and will complete two presentations and two writing assignments. Beginning in Week 2, two teams will present each week. The teams are designated Group A and Group B according to their assigned tasks. Each student must participate once in a Group A task and once in a Group B task.

Teams will be assigned randomly during the first class. Students may not change teams except under exceptional circumstances, such as a teammate withdrawing from the course. After the first class, each team must submit a team name and slogan, which will be added to the syllabus after team assignments are finalized.

Teams may choose either the “standard mode” or the “AI mode.”

The standard-mode tasks are as follows:

1. Group A presents the assigned readings for the week.
 - (a) Oral presentation: During the first class meeting of the week, Group A must designate one student to give a 15-minute presentation. Slides may be used. The 15-minute limit will be enforced strictly, and presentations exceeding it will be stopped. Slides must be uploaded no later than one hour before class.
 - (b) Content: Explain the main arguments, theoretical logic, and evidence of the assigned readings (70%). Discuss their contribution to the research topic and the dialogue or logical connections among them (30%). After the presentation, Group A should share **what the team learned from the readings** and respond to questions from classmates and the instructor.
 - (c) Written review: After the first class meeting, Group A must turn the presentation into a literature review of approximately 1,000 Chinese characters or an equivalent English length and post it on the discussion board for the class. The deadline is 00:00 on the Saturday after the presentation (24:00 Friday).
2. Group B presents an “extension” reading representing the **latest research development** on the week’s topic.
 - (a) Definition of an extension reading: An academic article or scholarly book published in 2019 or later in a leading Chinese- or English-language academic outlet that cites at least one assigned reading for the week. Books written for a general audience do not qualify. If no work citing the assigned readings can be found, select a study directly related to the topic and explain convincingly during the presentation why it is relevant.
 - (b) Group B should focus on one extension reading. At least one hour before class, upload its title, author, journal or publisher, and other bibliographic information in a standard citation format.
 - (c) Oral presentation: During the first class meeting of the week, Group B gives a 15-minute presentation after the discussion of Group A’s readings. Afterward, Group B responds to questions from classmates and the instructor.
 - (d) Content: Explain the main argument, theoretical logic, and evidence of the extension reading (50%). Discuss how it enters into a theoretical dialogue with the assigned readings (50%). Share **what the team learned from the article**.
 - (e) Written review: After the first class meeting, Group B must turn the presentation into a literature review of approximately 1,000 Chinese characters or an equivalent English length, framed around recent

developments in the week's topic, and post it on the discussion board. The deadline is 00:00 on the Saturday after the presentation (24:00 Friday).

The AI-mode requirements are the same as those for the standard mode, but all content must be produced **first** with AI tools. Students then act as "student instructors" who introduce and evaluate the AI-generated work. "Produced with AI tools" means that the substantive content is generated entirely by AI without human intervention. This includes generating slides directly with AI or generating text with AI and copying it onto slides.

1. Group A presents the assigned readings for the week.
 - (a) Oral presentation: Use AI tools to create the presentation slides and identify the tools and prompts used. In class, **present and evaluate** the slide content: use the AI-generated slides to introduce the readings, then criticize and supplement them. Add annotations to the AI-generated slides explaining the reasons for each correction or addition.
 - (b) Content: Explain the main arguments, theoretical logic, and evidence of the assigned readings (70%). Discuss their contribution to the topic and the dialogue or logical connections among them—that is, what the team learned from the readings (30%). After the presentation, Group A responds to questions from classmates and the instructor.
 - (c) Written review: Use an AI tool to produce the literature review. Use different font colors to identify the AI tool and prompts. Then annotate and revise the AI-generated review in another color, retaining the revision marks and comments that explain the reasons for each change.
2. Group B should follow the standard-mode content requirements and the AI-use instructions for Group A above.

3.2.1 Team Project Grading Criteria

1. Group A and Group B tasks are each graded out of 100 points.
2. Oral presentation: 50 points.
3. Written assignment: 50 points.
4. Expectations: The work should be concise, accessible, logically organized, and focused. Time and length should be managed appropriately.

3.2.2 Team Project Bonus

Teams presenting and commenting in Weeks 2 and 3 will receive bonuses of 8% and 4%, respectively, on their total team-project scores.

3.3 Final Paper

The final paper is a literature review.

Choose a narrow and highly specific research question or keyword related to comparative politics. Use Web of Science to identify all relevant publications in political science and international relations, then write a literature review based on that bibliography.

A literature review should not merely restate or summarize previous studies. It must advance a clear position, analyze connections and disagreements among studies, and offer logically and empirically grounded criticism. Criticism may address theoretical logic and explanation or empirical evidence.

Literature reviews are foundational to academic research because they identify research questions through a reasoned critique of limitations in previous work. Therefore, you must not only identify limitations but also provide persuasive arguments demonstrating that those limitations exist.

The conclusion should formulate an unresolved but researchable question.

A length of at least 1,500 Chinese characters or an equivalent English length is recommended. Grading is based on quality rather than length. Detailed principles and techniques for writing the paper will be covered in lectures and in feedback on class assignments. **Third-year students are encouraged to choose a possible undergraduate thesis topic and use this course to begin preparing for the thesis.**

Possible broad areas include democratization, economic development, ethnic conflict, welfare states, war, trade, state capacity, political stability, disinformation, political participation, and populism. These are broad themes; you must formulate a more specific research question.

Students may not submit identical topics. Topics are reserved on a first-come, first-served basis.

Literature-review schedule:

1. Before 00:00 on Sunday of Week 4: submit a proposed topic.
2. By 00:00 on Sunday of Week 5: confirm the final topic and upload the Web of Science bibliography.
3. Submit the final paper: date to be announced.

4 Assignment Format

1. Team assignments should use No. 5 SimSun font (approximately 10.5 pt). Submit assignments directly to the DingTalk group with the filename “Week’s Topic—Group A (or B) Assignment—[Team Name].pdf.” The document must list all authors and all AI tools used. Upload slides using the same naming convention.
2. Individual writing assignments must be submitted as Word documents, using No. 5 SimSun font (approximately 10.5 pt), single spacing, and 1 cm margins. Separate sections with subheadings.
3. All assignments must use the APSA Style Manual’s parenthetical citation and reference-list formats. See pages 38–57 of the APSA Style Manual: <https://mk0apsaconnectbvy6p6.kinstacdn.com/wp-content/uploads/sites/43/2018/11/Style-Manual-for-Political-Science-2018.pdf>.
4. Begin every assignment with the authors’ names, majors, and student ID numbers.

5 Course Materials

The course is organized around scholarly readings and has no required textbook. Each week, students will read three or more English-language works. Specific articles and books are listed in the course schedule. Students in Groups A and B must read the assigned works closely. Other students should read them selectively and study material of particular interest in greater depth when time permits. Required articles will be available through *Learning at ZJU*. I may also list additional materials in class or in the DingTalk group. Students are welcome to locate further readings and recommend materials to the class.

Each class session includes three or four relatively classic works and one more recent study. The second half of the first class meeting each week focuses on the research and writing logic of the recent study.

6 Software and Electronic Devices

1. Electronic devices are required for attendance, scoring, and voting. Otherwise, using a phone for unrelated content is prohibited. Violations will result in a deduction from the participation grade without an additional warning.
2. Handwritten note-taking, whether in a notebook or on a tablet, is encouraged, although typed notes are permitted. Photographing slides as a substitute for taking notes is discouraged. To reinforce this expectation, lecture slides will remain deliberately concise.

7 Use of Artificial Intelligence

1. You may use AI to assist with information collection and brainstorming, but you may not directly adopt an AI-generated writing plan as the argument of your paper. **Doing so will result in a failing grade.**
2. If AI services assist with your paper, cite or disclose their use in a standard format. Failure to disclose AI assistance will be treated as academic misconduct. For example, a footnote may state: “The description in this paragraph of the Iranian Revolution was synthesized by the AI tool DeepSeek. The information is supported by [cite reliable sources here]. The discussion connecting the Iranian Revolution to this paper’s theory was written by the author.”
3. AI is not a reliable source of information. Do not cite information supplied by an AI tool without locating and citing reliable sources.

8 Class Discussion

Students are encouraged to raise and discuss difficult questions. Students who think actively and contribute constructively may receive participation or bonus credit. During discussion, respect the views of others, address the issue rather than the person, and remain on topic.

9 Absence Policy

If you cannot attend class, email the instructor in advance. Medical absences require documentation from the university hospital, and official absences require documentation from the university.

10 Academic Integrity and Misconduct

The course has a zero-tolerance policy for academic misconduct. Except for team projects, all examinations and assignments must be completed independently and must be original work.

Academic misconduct includes, but is not limited to:

1. Copying text from previous publications or another student’s work and presenting it as original work.
2. Submitting a paper whose central claims and main argument are the same as those in a previous publication or another student’s work.
3. Using material from previous publications without citation and presenting it as original work.
4. Submitting text generated partly or entirely by an AI system, particularly when the cited studies or cases are unsupported by credible sources.
5. A final paper or examination exhibiting conduct described in Items 1, 2, or 4 will receive a score of zero. A single instance of conduct described in Item 3 will lower the grade by one letter grade; three instances will result in a score of zero.

11 Course Schedule

1. Syllabus introduction; team assignments; introduction to literature reviews; close reading of an article: April 29.
Guo, Li, and Chengli Wang. 2026. “Harnessing Star Power: Sequential Political Cooptation of Entertainment Celebrities in China.” *The International Journal of Press/Politics*. <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/abs/10.1177/19401612261422514> (April 7, 2026).
Concepts of institutions and institutionalist theories: April 30.

Rhodes, R. A. W., Sarah A. Binder, and Bert A. Rockman, eds. 2006. *The Oxford Handbook of Political Institutions*. Oxford ; New York: Oxford University Press.

Garlick, Alex, Wiebke Marie Junk, and Heath Brown. 2025. "How Lobbying Matters." *Annual Review of Political Science* 28(Volume 28, 2025): 457–75. doi:10.1146/annurev-polisci-033123-124920.

2. Party Politics: May 6 and May 7.

- Group A:
- Group B:
- *Colombo, Francesco, and Elias Dinas. 2023. "Networks of Grievances: Social Capital and Mainstream Party Decline." *Comparative Political Studies* 56(3): 363–94.
- Tavits, Margit. 2007. "Principle vs. Pragmatism: Policy Shifts and Political Competition." *American Journal of Political Science* 51(1): 151–65.
- Neto, Octavio Amorim, and Gary W Cox. 1997. "Electoral Institutions, Cleavage Structures, and the Number of Parties." *American Journal of Political Science* 41(1): 149–74.
- Chhibber, Pradeep, and Irfan Nooruddin. 2004. "Do Party Systems Count?: The Number of Parties and Government Performance in the Indian States." *Comparative Political Studies* 37(2): 152–87.

3. Social Policy and the Welfare State: May 13 and May 14.

- Group A:
- Group B:
- *Scheve, Kenneth, and Theo Serlin. 2023. "The German Trade Shock and the Rise of the Neo-Welfare State in Early Twentieth-Century Britain." *American Political Science Review* 117(2): 557–74. doi:10.1017/S0003055422000673.
- Immergut, Ellen M. 1990. "Institutions, Veto Points, and Policy Results: A Comparative Analysis of Health Care." *Journal of Public Policy* 10(4): 391–416.
- Iversen, Torben, and Frances Rosenbluth. 2006. "The Political Economy of Gender: Explaining Cross-National Variation in the Gender Division of Labor and the Gender Voting Gap." *American Journal of Political Science* 50(1): 1–19.
- Pontusson, Jonas, David Rueda, and Christopher R. Way. 2002. "Comparative Political Economy of Wage Distribution: The Role of Partisanship and Labour Market Institutions." *British Journal of Political Science* 32(02): 281–308.

4. Democratization—**topic proposal due**: May 20 and May 21.

- Group A:
- Group B:
- *Djuve, Vilde Lunnan, and Carl Henrik Knutsen. 2024. "Economic Crisis and Regime Transitions from Within." *Journal of Peace Research* 61(3): 446–61. doi:10.1177/00223433221145556.
- Treisman, Daniel. 2020. "Democracy by Mistake: How the Errors of Autocrats Trigger Transitions to Freer Government." *American Political Science Review* 114(3): 792–810.
- Boix, Carles, and Susan Carol Stokes. 2003. "Endogenous Democratization." *World Politics* 55(4): 517–49.
- Huntington, Samuel P. 1991. "Democracy's Third Wave." *Journal of Democracy* 2(2): 12–34.
- Ross, Michael L. 2001. "Does Oil Hinder Democracy?" *World Politics* 53(03): 325–61.

5. Populism and Democratic Backsliding—**finalize the topic and submit the bibliography**: May 27 and May 28.

- Group A:
- Group B:

- *Wunsch, Natasha, Marc S. Jacob, and Laurenz Derksen. 2025. "The Demand Side of Democratic Backsliding: How Divergent Understandings of Democracy Shape Political Choice." *British Journal of Political Science* 55: e39. doi:10.1017/S0007123424000711.
- Berman, Sheri. 1997. "Civil Society and the Collapse of the Weimar Republic." *World Politics* 49(3): 401–29.
- Diamond, Larry. 2021. "Democratic Regression in Comparative Perspective: Scope, Methods, and Causes." *Democratization* 28(1): 22–42. (Background reading.)
- Solt, Frederick. 2008. "Economic Inequality and Democratic Political Engagement." *American Journal of Political Science* 52(1): 48–60.
- Levitsky, Steven, and James Loxton. 2013. "Populism and Competitive Authoritarianism in the Andes." *Democratization* 20(1): 107–36.

6. Central–Local Relations and Federalism: June 3 and June 4.

- Group A:
- Group B:
- *Spohr, Florian, Patrick Bernhagen, and Krispin Krüger. 2025. "Subnational Lobbying on National Policymaking: Evidence From Germany." *Governance* 38(2): e70012. doi:10.1111/gove.70012.
- Cai, Hongbin, and Daniel Treisman. 2006. "Did Government Decentralization Cause China's Economic Miracle?" *World Politics* 58(04): 505–35. (Supplementary reading: Cai, Hongbin, and Daniel Treisman. 2004. "State Corroding Federalism." *Journal of Public Economics* 88(3): 819–43.)
- Rodden, Jonathan. 2002. "The Dilemma of Fiscal Federalism: Grants and Fiscal Performance around the World." *American Journal of Political Science* 46(3): 670–87.
- Brancati, Dawn. 2006. "Decentralization: Fueling the Fire or Dampening the Flames of Ethnic Conflict and Secessionism?" *International Organization* 60(3): 651–85.

7. Authoritarian Politics: Rule and Institutions: June 10 and June 11.

- Group A:
- Group B:
- *Liu, Hanzhang. 2024. "Meritocracy as Authoritarian Co-Optation: Political Selection and Upward Mobility in China." *American Political Science Review* 118(4): 1856–72. doi:10.1017/S000305542300120X.
- Gandhi, Jennifer, and Adam Przeworski. 2007. "Authoritarian Institutions and the Survival of Autocrats." *Comparative Political Studies* 40(11): 1279–1301.
- Nathan, Andrew J. 2003. "Authoritarian Resilience." *Journal of Democracy* 14(1): 6–17. Together with Gilley, Bruce. 2003. "The Limits of Authoritarian Resilience." *Journal of Democracy* 14(1): 18–26. Or Li, Cheng. 2012. "The End of the CCP's Resilient Authoritarianism? A Tripartite Assessment of Shifting Power in China." *The China Quarterly* 211: 595–623. (The first article is required; read at least one of the latter two.)
- Mesquita, Bruce Bueno de, and Alastair Smith. 2012. *The Dictator's Handbook: Why Bad Behavior Is Almost Always Good Politics*. Reprint edition. New York: PublicAffairs. Chapter 1 (not the Introduction).

8. Authoritarian Politics: Information and Media: June 17 and June 18.

- Group A:
- Group B:
- *Zhu, Jiangnan, Steve Bai, Siqin Kang, Juan Wang, and Kaixiao Liu. 2025. "Authoritarian Cue Effect of State Repression." *American Journal of Political Science* 69(4): 1420–34. doi:10.1111/ajps.12916
- Egorov, Georgy, Sergei Guriev, and Konstantin Sonin. 2009. "Why Resource-Poor Dictators Allow Freer Media: A Theory and Evidence from Panel Data." *American Political Science Review* 103(04): 645–668.

- Geddes, Barbara, and John Zaller. 1989. "Sources of Popular Support for Authoritarian Regimes." *American Journal of Political Science* 33(2): 319–47.
- Stromseth, Jonathan R. et al. 2017. *China's Governance Puzzle: Enabling Transparency and Participation in a Single-Party State*. Cambridge, United Kingdom ; New York, NY, USA: Cambridge University Press. Chapter 1.